

Which of the following is true, according to the Mead theory of identity development?

- ✓ ☒ A. The "me" is the aspect of self that is formed through interactions with others. [52%]
- ☐ B. The "I" is the aspect of self that is formed during the game stage. [8%]
- ☐ C. The "looking-glass self" results from an individual's cumulative lifetime of interactions with others. [12%]
- ☐ D. The "front-stage self" involves behaving in ways that align with social norms and expectations. [26%]

Correct

52% answered correctly

Explanation:

Theory of the social self: George Herbert Mead

Stage	Age	Learning process	Developing self
Preparatory	Infancy, toddler	Imitation: often lacks understanding	
Play	Preschool age	Role-taking: taking on role of specific others	
Game	School age	Generalized other: understanding all roles & overarching rules	

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George Herbert **Mead**, who is most associated with the sociological theory of symbolic interactionism, argued that **social** (rather than biological) factors **influence identity formation**. Mead suggested that the experience of "self" emerges through social interaction with others who play important and formative roles in one's life (eg, family). The two aspects of the self are the "I" and "me," which develop in stages:

- **Preparatory** (or imitation): Babies/toddlers imitate others (eg, a parent's hand gesture) and begin using symbols and language (eg, repeating a phrase used by a parent) without meaning comprehension. At this stage, children have no sense of "self" as separate from the world around them.
- **Play**: Through play (eg, pretending to be a doctor), preschool-age children begin **role-taking** (ie, understanding the perspectives of others). When children understand themselves as individuals separate from others, the "I" component of the self has developed. Children then begin to imagine how others perceive them, which is the beginning of the development of the "me."
- **Game**: School-age children become aware of their position/role in relation to others. They begin to see themselves from the perspective of the more abstract **generalized other**, further developing the "me" to incorporate the values and rules of the society in which they live.

(Choice B) According to the Mead theory, the "me," not the "I," is formed through interactions with others during the game stage.

(Choice C) Charles Cooley (not Mead) proposed the concept of the looking-glass self, suggesting that beliefs about oneself are derived through social interactions with others throughout one's lifetime. The Mead theory differs from the Cooley theory by suggesting that interactions *early in life* result in one's conception of self or identity.

(Choice D) The dramaturgical perspective of Erving Goffman (not Mead) explains social behavior using a theater metaphor; the front-stage self involves individuals behaving as "actors" in front of an "audience," whereas the back-stage self includes the behaviors in which an individual engages more privately.

Educational objective:

George Herbert Mead proposed that identity formation is the result of social interactions, particularly with significant others, early in life. During the preparatory stage, babies/toddlers imitate others without comprehension. During the play stage, children begin understanding the perspectives of specific others (role-taking). During the game stage, children begin understanding the perspectives of others in society (generalized other) and social interaction rules.

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